

As ships’ fuel costs soar, you may pay the price

Firms are imposing surcharges and avoiding expensive routes amid Iran War.

By CAROLINE PETROW-COHEN

The massive ships that glide through the ports of Los Angeles and Long Beach are facing extreme fuel costs as oil prices rise, often paying millions of dollars more to top off their titanic tanks.

The cost of filling up with shipping fuel in L.A. County is close to 20% higher than at other major ports in the U.S. and worldwide. The rates at the ports in Los Angeles and Long Beach also have risen by more than at other ports since the war in Iran began.

With some ships requiring the equivalent of millions of gallons of fuel after they drop off and pick up cargo, the extra costs add up. Shipping companies are taking steps to reduce fuel consumption and avoid expensive routes, but much of that extra cost eventually will show up in the prices of the many products transported in the hundreds of thousands of containers that pass through the ports every month.

“If someone asks you to ship something, you’re still going to do it, you’re just going to quote them a higher price,” said Mike Jacob, president of the Pacific Merchant Shipping Assn. “Higher supply chain costs ultimately have to be paid by someone.”

The price of gas for automobiles has jumped more than 50%, making everyone’s commute more costly. Truckers are struggling with sky-high diesel prices and higher aviation fuel prices have lifted airfares and even led to the closure of Spirit Airlines.

Higher shipping fuel costs also are expected to continue contributing to inflation, even if there were an immediate resolution to the conflict with Iran.

The closure of the Strait of Hormuz since late February has blocked a large portion of the global oil supply from flowing freely, and uncertainty surrounding the conflict has kept oil prices volatile.

A fragile ceasefire continues despite violence in the Strait in recent days.

As with other types of fuel in the state, taxes, fees and environmental restrictions

[See Shipping, A11]

Alleged suicide note is unsealed

Document purportedly written by Epstein has film quotations he had included previously in emails. **NATION, A4**

Blame game at mayoral debate

Candidates point fingers over the Palisades fire, LAPD pay raises, homelessness and more. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Lakers coverage against Thunder

For coverage of Game 2 against Oklahoma City, visit [latimes.com/enewspaper](#) and [latimes.com/sports](#).

Weather

Mostly sunny. L.A. Basin: 75/57. **B6**

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GREGORY BULL Associated Press

WORKING ON TIJUANA RIVER

A research team from UC San Diego studies the polluted waterway on the U.S. side in March. A coalition of experts, activists and politicians has unveiled a plan to clean up the river. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Wilshire subway extension is big test of Angelenos’ taste for rail

By GRACE TOOHEY, JENNY JARVIE AND KAREN GARCIA

On paper, the D Line should be a slam-dunk for Los Angeles mass transit.

It runs through the heart of the city, covering some of L.A.’s densest communities as well as landmarks such as LACMA and the Academy Museum. Its stations are only a few blocks from the

Grove and Beverly Center.

But getting Angelenos out of their cars and onto mass transit will probably be a challenge, and experts say the D Line could be a major test of whether adding rail in prime real estate can change behavior.

Success of the line, some say, will ultimately hinge on its utility, reliability and the inconvenience of alternatives — and it’s far from clear that calculus will make it a

daily commute favorite, especially right away.

It needs to be “the best way to get around,” said Brian Taylor, a professor of urban planning and public policy at UCLA’s Luskin School of Public Affairs and a research fellow at the university’s Institute of Transportation Studies.

That becomes the case, he said, when the rail line is convenient, timely and consistent, while driving be-

comes less attractive: Interstate traffic remains a challenge, parking options are expensive or limited and fuel prices remain high.

Some Metro lines have achieved this success. The A Line, which runs from Long Beach to the San Gabriel Valley, has long packed in passengers, with almost 17 million weekday riders a year in 2025, close to its pre-pandemic levels. But it is

[See Metro, A7]

S.F. fortunes rise while L.A.’s go south

The Bay Area’s AI tech boom, population gain contrast with local woes

By TERRY CASTLEMAN

The COVID-19 pandemic brought tough times for both Los Angeles and San Francisco.

Crime briefly rose. Rising housing prices — combined with the opportunity to work remotely — led to declines in population. Concerns over blight and quality of life became political issues.

But now there are early signs of a post-crisis divergence in fortunes between the two cities.

A tale of two cities

San Francisco is in the midst of a new tech boom fueled by artificial intelligence that has attracted residents to the city and boosted the downtown economy. The city netted a small increase in population last year, ac-

cording to new U.S. census data.

Los Angeles — and its surrounding county — by contrast, is still struggling. Population losses are continuing, and its economy is being hit by several forces — including a shrinking Hollywood industry and President Trump’s immigration policies, which have slowed growth and upended some business sectors.

It will take many more years to see whether this becomes a larger trend. Demographers say the San Francisco boost is notable, but far from a sign of boom times ahead.

In fact, many experts say high housing prices and other factors continue to make more affordable cities outside California very attractive, especially to young-

[See Cities, A6]



Los Angeles Times

L.A. OFFICERS question and warn off young migrants in Colton in 1936.

COLUMN ONE

When poverty was an offense

In the Dust Bowl era, L.A. police barred indigent fellow Americans from entering the state

By Hailey Branson-Potts | REPORTING FROM HORNBROOK, CALIF.

The expeditionary force, a squad of officers from the Los Angeles Police Department, deployed to this rugged little mountain town near the Oregon border with a singular mission.

Stationing themselves along the Southern Pacific Railroad tracks, the officers eyeballed passengers on California-bound trains, looking for hints of poverty: dirty clothes, worn luggage, or, simply, a weary expression.

If the riders looked shabby? The police stopped them from entering the Golden State.

This country has long argued over who should be allowed in. It still does. But nine decades ago here in this speck of a town called Hornbrook, an extraordinary episode in U.S. immigration history unfolded: Americans trying to stop fellow Americans from crossing state lines.

[See Blockade, A6]

Housing crisis looms for fire victims

Nearly half in the Palisades, Altadena say insurance funds are running out.

By GRACE TOOHEY

Facing dwindling — or already dried up — insurance payouts and increasingly expensive rebuilding estimates, Los Angeles County’s fire survivors appear to be headed for the most urgent and existential financial crisis yet in their recovery, according to a survey taken 15 months after the January 2025 firestorms.

The report released Thursday by the Department of Angels, a fire recovery nonprofit launched after much of Altadena and Pacific Palisades were destroyed in the Eaton and Palisades fires, marks the organization’s fifth quarterly survey of about 2,100 fire survivors.

It noted some marginal progress in the overall recovery but also found “large and widening gaps between the recovery paths of different survivors,” particularly when accounting for respondents’ income levels and race and ethnicity.

The highest percentage yet of fire survivors — nearly half, according to the survey — said they had either run out of temporary housing insurance payments or expected to soon, signaling “an impending end of coverage for many more survivors before they are able to return home.”

About 40% of respondents said they would be able to afford temporary housing only for a few months, if that, without those insurance payments.

And the findings were even more urgent for lower-income households: Among those earning \$50,000 or less, almost 80% said they didn’t think they could afford housing for three months once coverage ended.

“Long-term finances are the most urgent issue for survivors, even as they face a

[See Survivors, A5]

This device may end high-speed chases

Law enforcement’s new secret weapon is the Grappler, which lassos fleeing vehicles.

By ANDREW J. CAMPA

It was on a Sunday morning in mid-March when Riverside County sheriff’s personnel attempted a vehicle stop at Perris Boulevard and Iris Avenue in Moreno Valley. The driver sped away.

But deputies had a trick up their sleeve — a secret weapon that is part grappling gun, part lasso.

The device, known as the Grappler, was released from where it was installed on the front bumper of a sheriff’s vehicle and onto the fleeing suspect’s back tires. Within seconds, the vehicle was halted off the 60 Freeway exit at Country Village Road, and the suspect was left as powerless as a rodeo calf on its side.

“That move, that grapple, prevented him from driving on the wrong side and potentially from crashing into another vehicle,” said Riverside County Sheriff’s Lt. Jason Santistevan.

For the deputy, that success confirmed the effectiveness of a system he had persuaded the department to

adopt. The Riverside County Sheriff’s Department joins a growing number of law enforcement agencies trying out a relatively new technology in an attempt to curb chases and the injuries and deaths that can follow. Santistevan said he is determined to reduce bystander casualties.

The Grappler is generating excitement in some corners of law enforcement as officials look for new ways to deal with high-speed pursuits. Faced with innocent bystanders being hurt — even killed — during the chases, some agencies have at times called off pursuits in the interest of safety. Spike strips rolled onto roadways in front of pursued cars work sometimes, as does the “PIT maneuver,” in which patrol cruisers tap the suspect’s car in an effort to cause it to spin out and come to a stop.

Although the Grappler has fans in law enforcement, there are also those who say the jury is still out on how effective this tool will be.

The California Highway Patrol reported 13,627 pursuits in 2023, with 19% (2,593) resulting in a crash. The previous year, 12,000 pursuits were recorded, of which 19% (2,275) ended in a crash. There were 43 deaths in 2023, up from 34 the previous

[See Grappler, A7]